# 10 Harmful or Useless? Victor Papanek and the Danish Design Students' Protests

*Anders V. Munch, Alison J. Clarke, Vibeke Riisberg and Lene Kiærbye Pedersen*

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> *It is the job of the students together with their faculty to change the university; and, once changed, to preserve the university as an instrument of change for society at large.*
>
> Victor Papanek (1970)

Victor Papanek dedicated his book, *Design for the Real World*, 'to all his students thanking them for what they had taught him'. He might have been thinking of both his American students and the Scandinavian students he met at summer schools and lectures at Nordic architectural and design schools in the late 1960s. The latter taught him lessons in design activism, user involvement and collaboration that showed new methods for industrial design, in order to prevent it from being the most 'harmful profession' – together with advertising – in the ways, it helped accelerate global consumption and waste, social inequality and pollution (Papanek 1971a; Clarke 2013). He lectured in Denmark several times from 1969 on, and moved to Copenhagen as a guest professor for one year in 1972/1973. So he both inspired and experienced the student protests and reform processes at the Danish schools of architecture and design during the most turbulent years. Some of his ideas on design education were published in Danish as well, and this makes it interesting to compare these ideas with the events, debates and reforms at the Danish schools.

The protests and reforms in Denmark were, of course, part of the broader international developments of student rebellion, youth movements and political activism. What makes this case interesting from an international perspective is a radical use of direct democracy at the schools involving students, teachers and principals, and the introduction of open student admission at the schools of architecture. Papanek felt inspired by Danish design and often referred to Danish examples of usability and simplicity, especially in his and James Hennessey's *Nomadic Furniture I & II*. His stay in Denmark, however, and his experience teaching at the Department of Industrial Design at the Royal Academy School of Architecture for one year gave him a rather different view of the Danish students and their involvement through direct democracy (Clarke 2016, 2021). In an interview shortly before leaving the Academy in August 1973, he expressed deep disappointment with the students. Even a comparison with kindergartens would be unjust – to the kindergartens – because the children showed

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much more curiosity and discipline than the majority of the Academy students. He concluded with another comparison:

> ... if my daughter was ill, I would not send her to a doctor who is educated the way you are educated at the Academy. Imagine entrusting yourself to a brain surgeon who has spent five years studying the way you study here. It would be better to just put a bullet through your brain — less painful anyway.
>
> (Papanek 1973)

The historical investigation of student activism, design critique and educational reforms around 1970 is an important reminder of an engaged criticism – which is much needed again – but also of many unfortunate experiences with educational experiments that we do not have to repeat, as Papanek's verdict indicates. The focus of this investigation is on how the students' desire to have an impact on society was articulated in their actions, and how it developed with the changes in the schools. Initially, many students felt that their education taught them useless skills with rare possibilities for employment, and they were far removed from the impact of changing the harmfulness of design consumption, as expressed during their debates and meetings. Though, the wish for more elective courses and open possibilities for individual development in the programmes was also on the agenda, see the interviews in Chapter 9. Some of the political experiments with direct democracy, however, turned out to be harmful to their education as well, especially at the School of Architecture. So, our main question is: On which issues did the paths of Papanek and the Danish students diverge?1

## Design schools and reforms in Denmark 1967–1976

In order to outline the reforms, understand the rebellion and related events an overview of Danish design and architecture schools around 1970 is provided as an introduction to this section.

| *Institution and location* | *Design departments* |
|---|---|
| Royal Danish Academy School of Architecture, Copenhagen | Industrial Design, Graphics and Furniture |
| School of Arts and Crafts, Copenhagen (after 1973 The School of Applied Arts) | Textile, Ceramics, Furniture, Graphics, and Fashion |
| Kolding School of Arts and Crafts, Kolding | Textile, Graphics, Fashion, and Ceramics |
| Aarhus School of Architecture, Aarhus | Industrial Design and Furniture |
| School of Interior Design, Copenhagen | Interior design and Furniture |

Our investigation so far has been focussed on the first three institutions on this list[2]:

**Royal Danish Academy School of Architecture** *(Det Kongelige Danske Kunstakademis Arkitektskole*) founded its department of furniture in 1924 and its department

of industrial design in 1957. The Academy followed a Beaux-Arts or art school tradition, and the polytechnical tradition only played a marginal role in Danish design and architecture.

**School of Arts and Crafts** (*Kunsthåndværkerskolen*) was under the Copenhagen Technical Schools, but the staff were a mix of subject-specific teachers, architects and artists. Its curriculum and statutes were influenced by industrial organisations and rules and regulations were decided by the Danish Ministry of Industry under the system of vocational education.

**Kolding School of Arts and Crafts** was established in 1967 as part of the local technical school under the same rules as the Copenhagen school.

In 1967, the School of Arts and Crafts in Copenhagen was merged with the independent School of Drawing and Industrial Arts (*Tegne- og Kunstindustriskolen*), originally a women's school, which mainly had programmes in graphic design and fashion by this time. These two schools were combined under the provisional name, *Kunsthåndværker- og Kunstindustriskolen*, that is, 'School of Arts and Crafts and Industrial Arts', but usually just called the School of Arts and Crafts. The provisional name signalled a long transitional period with standing committees working on new statutes and more contemporary curricula until it was changed to the independent School of Applied Arts (*Skolen for Brugskunst*) in 1973 under the Ministry of Education. This long process was affected by impatient students, critical of both the quality and relevance of their education. A strong desire of both the principal and the students throughout this period was to elevate the schools to an institution of higher education with research, as happened in the other Nordic countries during the 1970s, see Chapter 8. In Denmark, only the Royal Academy School of Architecture had obtained this higher status around 1950 (Millech 1954).

It was at the School of Arts and Crafts and the School of Architecture in Copenhagen that the most radical protests and educational experiments took place. The relatively young principal of the School of Arts and Crafts, appointed in 1967, Ole Gjerløv-Knudsen (1930–2009), also wanted reforms and agreed with much of the students' criticism. But he had a difficult job in changing the statutes of the school, obtaining independence and new educational regulations, maintaining funding from the Ministry of Education and negotiating new forms of education with protesting students. The official, annual reports of 1966/1967 and 1967/1968 featured both his own reflections on the need for reform and debates by students and other stakeholders. The front cover of the latter report stated a subtle critique, picturing a locked bird cage with the three primary, geometric forms symbolising the school and the Bauhaus ideals in the cage (Figure 10.1). On the back page of the report, the door is open and the cage empty. The report from 1968/1969, the very year of protest actions, however, gave less voice to the critique. The actual student actions were only described briefly:

> The problems linked to future educational regulations have caused an array of principal activities among the students, including a week of debate, a group of interest, a protest march, a forest of protest signs and the boycott of exams.
>
> (Gjerløv-Knudsen 1969)

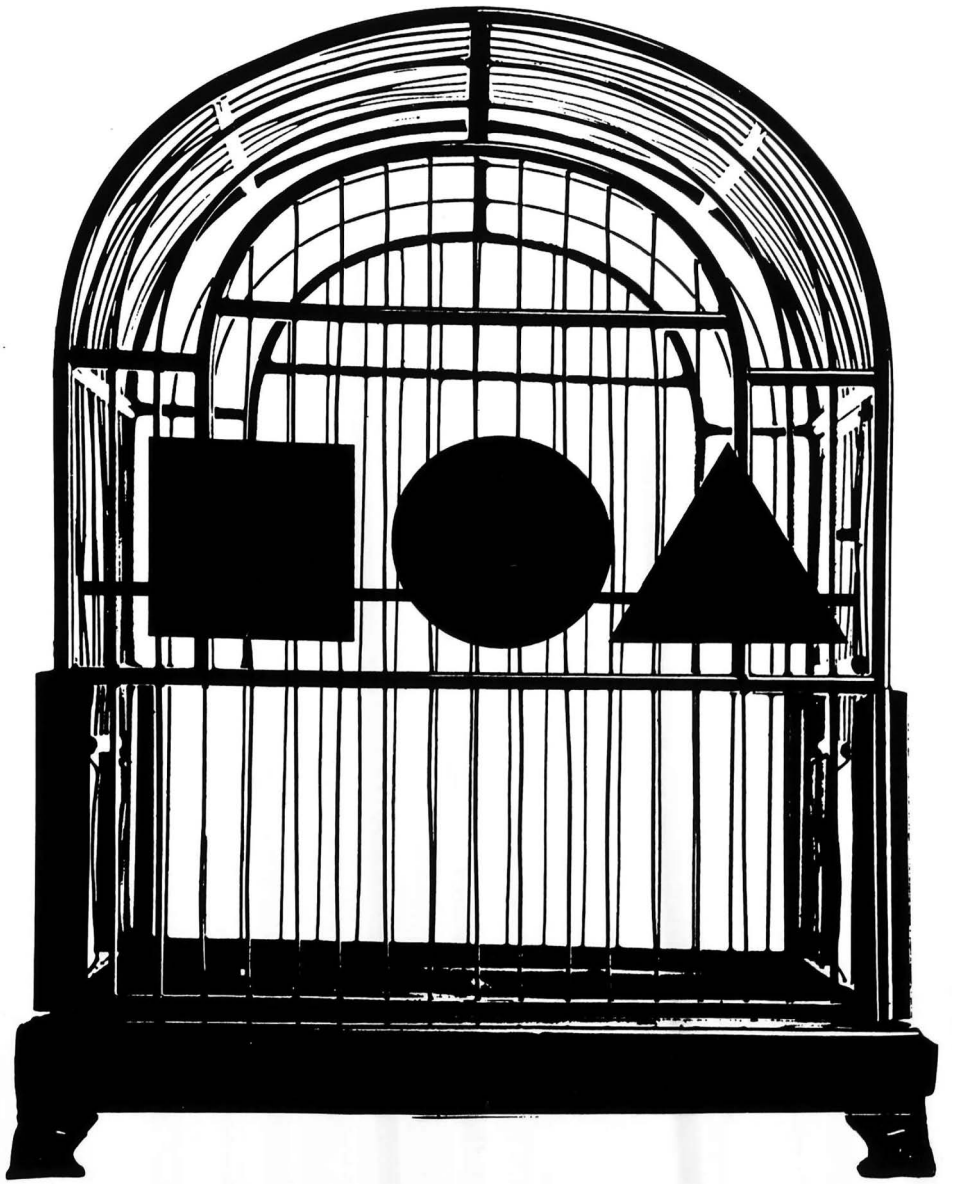


*Figure 10.1* Front cover of the annual report of *Kunsthåndværker- og Kunstindustriskolen* 1967/68. Archive of the Royal Danish Academy Library.

## The student rebellion

A brief history of this student rebellion begins at the School of Architecture. Taken as a whole this school was much larger than the School of Arts and Crafts and the architect students collaborated closely with students from Sociology and Psychology at the universities, who were the leading groups in the Danish student rebellion. In March 1968 different manifestos on open study programmes led to a three-day debate meeting and a Students' Plenary (*Elevforsamlingen*) was established to obtain a stronger influence on the school. An official board of students' representatives (*Elevrådet*) was dissolved by the students themselves in both the School of Architecture and the School of Arts and Crafts due to their mistrust in representative democracy. The students of the much smaller School of Arts and Crafts did not establish a similar permanent plenary but took action to invite state officials, industrial leaders and design professionals to a debate on the societal role of design and the quality of their education in February 1969. This was rather effective, as the state agency of vocational education offered permanent positions for six new heads of programmes in the following days. However, both the principal and the students continued negotiations independently, and a group of students went directly to the Minister of Education. The students also skipped classes for a week and arranged plenary debates with invited guests from industry, as well as activists in politics and research, to discuss professional conditions and societal challenges.

Independence from the narrow vocational school regulations and the status of higher education was central to the students of the School of Arts and Crafts. Thus, on 3 March 1969, they joined forces with students from the School of Architecture at a demonstration in front of the Danish Ministry of Culture, where representatives from the School of Architecture were attending a meeting. The demonstration developed into an occupation of the Ministry for one hour, which got the attention of the public media (Figure 9.1). The protests continued later with a boycott of exams in April at the School of Arts and Crafts as explained in the interviews, Chapter 9. As a result, five students were expelled from the school according to the regulations, and this led to renewed demonstrations, including the occupation of the offices of the principal and the director of the technical schools. The general demands of the students were the abolition of admissions tests, grades and exams as well as influence on curriculum and faculty positions.

Apart from the boycott of exams, the school administration was quite open to negotiations, as they were working on new regulations themselves. Unofficial study boards with equal representation of students and teachers were established at both the School of Arts and Crafts and the School of Architecture in the spring of 1969. Many teachers, especially the large group of young assistants without permanent contracts, agreed with the students' critique. At the School of Architecture, they even agreed with the critique of the admissions tests, and as a result, they were cancelled, allowing for open, free admission to the study programme. As one of the most radical achievements of the Danish student rebellion in general, the two schools of architecture in Copenhagen and Aarhus had open admission between 1970 and 1977. The number of students quickly tripled, but the state funding did not increase. And as experiments with new kinds of teaching or open, individual study activities flourished, this developed into a rather volatile situation. Despite collaboration and equal representation in the school board, the Students' Plenary insisted on direct democracy and held on to its

stronghold in many ways, for example, through plenary meetings at the departments in order to influence curriculum and faculty positions.

The archives from this period are scant and there seems to be neither continuous annual reports nor school magazines during the most turbulent years of 1970–1972. Interviews with former students and teachers are needed as a supplement to archival sources, and Chapter 9 presents interviews with three participants in the student rebellion. The archives contained one issue of a school magazine from the Kolding School of Arts and Crafts called *The Sprout*, Spring 1971, which contains extensive comments on the situation. There is an article by the young teacher Ole Sørensen called 'An Attempt at an Analysis of the Arts and Crafts Education Today and Proposal for Alternative Problematics'. It states the problem with vocational training stemming from an apprenticeship in crafts at a time when students are more mature, experienced and critical towards bourgeois societal organisation. He concludes:

> A highly relevant new kind of thinking in design education must rely on: confidence in the intentions and skills of the student, confidence in the disciplinary competence of the teacher, huge flexibility in the planning and implementation of the course of study, the student taking responsibility for the benefits of his/her study, the elimination of useless exams, openness in all questions concerning the well-being of the school, democratic collaboration between all parties involved in the administration and practice of the school.
>
> (Sørensen 1971)

The schools of arts and crafts did not introduce open admission as the schools of architecture did, but they did create more flexible regulations and embarked on many social and psychological experiments with teamwork and individual creative emancipation. In 1973, the Copenhagen School of Arts and Crafts became independent from the Technical School and was reorganised under its new name, School of Applied Arts. The student activism, however, continued.

## Papanek and the students' agenda

In January 1969, one month before the first debate event initiated by the students at the School of Arts and Crafts, Papanek visited the school and lectured on design for disability and social design. He returned in June for the third SDO Summer School, 'Human and Environment II', arranged by the Scandinavian Design Students' Organisation and held at the School of Arts and Crafts in Copenhagen (Lie 2014, 2016). Papanek was engaged in all the summer schools and developed his ideas on collaboration and user participation together with the students (Clarke 2013, 2021). A year earlier at *Konstfack* in Stockholm, he had lectured on his ideas on design education. In Copenhagen, the lectures and group work focussed again on different human environments, and Papanek developed his famous *Copenhagen Chart*, a flow chart sketching all the challenges and possible collaborations of the designer through distinctions between the false and genuine needs of all kinds of people. SDO was established in 1966 as a platform of discussion on design education and societal critique. It had members from School of Arts and Crafts, the School of Architecture and later the Kolding School of Arts and Crafts, so it had a role on the Danish design

students' protests. Ida Kamilla Lie and Kaisu Savola have investigated the sources of SDO through student members (Lie 2014; Savola 2018).

It is also vital to understand the student revolts of this period in the context of the broader geopolitics of the Nordic region. When the Danish Furniture Manufacturers' prominent magazine, *Mobilia*, published a polemical article *What to Design and Why* by Papanek as self-proclaimed social designer – the year before his guest professorship at the Royal Academy – it placed on its front cover a low-technology design artefact aimed at the Global South: a discarded vehicle licence plate re-fashioned into a moveable stove on which, the accompanying editorial declared, a Mexican 'family cooks all of their meals' (Papanek 1971b). Other self-assembly and alternative technology designs included a co-design project with James Hennessey, namely a portable cooler that could be powered by a windable handle, for distribution in Lesotho, South Africa. The design's radicalism resided in its adaption for local use: 'Instead of using imported Styrofoam, we can build a box-form and line it with old newspaper pages […] the design has been given to UNESCO' (Papanek 1971b).

It was no coincidence that, a year prior to becoming a popular figure within the Danish design fraternity, Papanek had been featured in the same journal discussing 'TVs for educational uses in the Third World […] and power sources for emerging nations,' further asserting that 'design must always be operative, that is, socially relevant and responsive to change. Design cannot avoid being a social, political and revolutionary tool' (Papanek 1970). These appeals to the politics of inequality within the Global South and engagement with development agencies, although coming from an American designer-activist, appealed to the contemporaneous discourse (and controversies) regarding the extension of newly imagined Scandinavian welfare models into recently independent countries (for a broader discussion of this theme see Clarke, 2022). Reports of the period, for example, an overview titled the 'Scandinavian Development Agreements with African Countries' (1971) published by the *Scandinavian Institute of African Studies*, Sweden, emphasised 'the readiness of the African countries to enter into bilateral agreements with Scandinavian countries on account of their non-colonial past and above all their resolute stand in the decolonisation of Africa and apartheid' (Widstrand and Zdenek Červenka 1971, 18). While postcolonial scholars have pointed out the 'myth' of the non-complicity model of Nordic and Scandinavian colonial history, as a facet of social design and student activism in the late 1960s and 1970s, the Global South (or 'Third World') issues, and particularly the politics of Pan-Africanism extended the revolts in design and architecture departments way beyond intrigues of individual design schools.

Here we will focus on Papanek's own statements on design education and compare them to the debates and events in Denmark. Some of his thoughts on design education were published in *Mobilia* in 1970 under the English title *An Alternative to Sterility*. The magazine made four-language issues, and the Danish had a slightly different heading: 'On Design and Design Education'. We assume this text is rather close to the issues he discussed with the students in the SDO summer schools and at the School of Arts and Crafts in Copenhagen. It sums up an agenda of actions to democratise design education:

> We must also (as we have already begun) democratise our process by: (a) Including students as full voting members on all levels of the design program, dealing with education, research and service; (b) establishing a policy-generating faculty-student team; (c) bringing students in to help us elect new faculty and evaluate

> present faculty through a basis of free choice; (d) having students help us in writing future curricula; (e) having both faculty and students spend more time on constructive mutual criticism and self-criticism; (f) having students and faculty together demonstrate the relevance of design to our society.
>
> (Papanek 1970).

In the spring of 1969, the students at the School of Arts and Crafts had joined new study boards with the same level of representation as the faculty. They were engaged in decisions on both courses and policy and were involved in electing new faculty the following years. While they seem to have had a fair vote in decisions on curriculum, it is difficult to determine how they may have used it based on the sparse archival sources available. The debates seem to have been the most successful element, arranged by either students or young part-time tutors. And this continued when the school got its independence in 1973 and was renamed as the School of Applied Arts. One debate seminar arranged by a teacher of ceramics, Ursula Munch-Petersen, with speakers from the profession and industry as well as critics, was praised in an issue of, 'The School Magazine' (*Skolebladet*) in 1974. The same teacher also developed material for a course called 'Societal Conditions and Culture' (*Samfundsforhold og kultur*) together with artist Erik Hagens (Munch-Petersen & Hagens 1974). This was also an early demand by the students that the role of their profession in society should be addressed and discussed in the curriculum (Figure 10.2).

There was also a demand for elective courses and interdisciplinary projects, so that students could choose more freely, develop individually and thereby attain more



*Figure 10.2* Plenary evaluation of the first-year thematic workshop with the assignment One Year at Hesselø (a small Danish island), 10–14 November 1975, The School of Applied Arts, Copenhagen. Archive of the Royal Danish Academy Library (also reproduced in *Skolebladet* Dec 1975), photographer unknown.

complex professional profiles to handle societal challenges. The sources are more tacit on the resulting activities. Some students made their own projects outside the schools and demanded having their products, for example, a film on workers' conditions, accepted for evaluation. The school arranged thematic weeks, where all programmes worked with the same overarching theme to train students in interdisciplinary work and problem-solving for broader societal challenges. Whether these themes were suggested by the students or faculty is unclear. But one issue of the Copenhagen school magazine in 1975 is dedicated to the critique of such a one-week first-year project for all new students. The statement of purpose from the school regulations was even printed on the front cover to remind everyone of their mission (*Skolebladet* 1975). The most critical student states in the magazine that he quit the project on the day of its initiation – in order to write his critique. The faculty had to constantly explore new ways to teach, as the students had no clear consensus in their critique. One of the authors of this chapter started at the School of Arts and Crafts in 1971 and found the tutors a bit lost in how to meet the demands of a new kind of students. Psychologists were invited to do group exercises in a week-long workshop, which some of the students strongly objected to. Images from this event show various attitudes and postures that reveal the mutual opposition of both teachers and students to any established norms in a learning situation – staged on wooden crates for Danish aquavit (Figure 10.3).

When comparing the list of changes suggested by Papanek in the 1970 article to democratise design education, quoted on page 148–149, with the archival sources, it is clear that the first four goals of student empowerment and participation in decisions



*Figure 10.3* Debate, first-year workshop, the School of Arts and Crafts, 1971. Archive of the Royal Danish Academy Library, photographer unknown.

on educational programmes were reached at the Danish schools. This was an important improvement to Danish design education. Regarding the latter two goals concerning collaboration with faculty, though, it seems evident that the wish of 'having both faculty and students spend more time on constructive mutual criticism and self-criticism' succeeded, but somehow at the cost of mutual demonstration of 'the relevance of design to our society'. Both faculty and students ended up spending endless amounts of time on 'criticism and self-criticism'. In Papanek's later critique of the Danish students, based on his experiences at the Royal Academy Department of Industrial Design in 1972/73, he scorned the endless plenary meetings that never resulted in any actions or changes. Ideological discussions were repeated endlessly with a new audience at each meeting. Papanek refers to how he asked several times for a representational organisation of the democratic processes to secure some continuity, but the students voted against it. 'This is neither Marxism nor direct or representational democracy. This is adjusted Fascism – that is the Marxist expression for this concept' (Papanek 1973). The students favoured 'direct democracy', and their leaders misused it to produce a permanent emergency situation where any deal or decision could be cancelled. This was not what Papanek had imagined with his demand for 'including all students as full voting members'. And when he asked the students to work together with him on mutual projects, they left. His ideas for a more critically engaged design education were in parallel with many experimental activities at Danish schools, but the study culture did not quite turn out as he had initially hoped:

> The biggest lie told to students is, that they are in school here to learn to 'make a living'. In fact, they are here to start a life-long process of education, in which some of us can sometimes help them for a time. While there are discrete skills in design, any increase in 'professionalization' is so outdated as to be ludicrous. A series of intensified undergraduate workshops should allow the student to create his own cross-disciplinary mix from the arts, social and behavioral sciences, etc.
>
> (Papanek 1970, up)

The question is whether the Danish students shared his ideal picture of higher education – or ever had the proper conditions to pursue it. Despite his appreciation of Danish design, Papanek might not have realised how different both the academic and craft traditions, as well as the institutional situation of the schools, were from his polytechnical background (Clarke 2018). In fact, the rebellion at the School of Arts and Crafts as a tiny school and part of the vocational education system started out with the demand for learning in order to 'make a living' as professionals. Danish design culture did not experience the same professionalisation as the US in the 1950s and 1960s. The declared ambition of this epoque might have been for higher education, driven by critical engagement and artistic experiments. However, the high ideal of 'a life-long process of education', assisted by visionary teachers such as Papanek, in many cases turned into fragmented activities around individual emancipation or political organisation, neither fitting into the interdisciplinary teams of social intervention from Papanek's vision nor the job positions of the Danish design industry.

The two major design schools in Denmark, in Copenhagen and in Kolding, did obtain the level of higher education and status as research institutions as late as 2010, so this turned out to be a rather long transition. And this was at a time where any

ideas of open admission were long gone, and the influence of students as well as teachers was diminished by a university reform in 2003. Despite his fierce critique of the students in 1973, Papanek kept close connections to Denmark and inspired the continuous development of sustainable design, participatory design and social design.

## Notes

1 This is a work in progress as sources have been sparse and incomplete, and an earlier version of this chapter has been presented at ICDHS 2020 (Munch et al. 2020).
2 The School of Interior Design (*Skolen for Boligindretning* ) under Frederiksberg's Technical School, also in Copenhagen, opened in 1934 and merged with the School of Applied Arts in 1990 into Denmark's Design School (now merged with the Royal Academy under this name). We have not yet found any documentation or comments regarding either reforms or radical protests there. The second school of architecture was opened in Aarhus in 1965 (Poulsen 2015). We have not looked into their archives.

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